

ENGR 392: Impact of Technology on Society

Policy Proposal Group Project

General Information: In small groups (4-5 students), you will identify a sociotechnical problem and propose a solution. This project will culminate in a presentation due at the end of the semester. You will also write a brief report to accompany the presentation that will include a bibliography. We will address the project steps throughout the semester.

Step 1 – Topic Proposal (10%): Due January 30 by email.

A sociotechnical problem is a situation where the relationship between society and technology is in some way unsatisfactory. For example, the installation of a highly polluting industrial plant next to a community that lacks the political power to regulate it is both a technical problem (insofar as there may be ways to mitigate the pollution) and a social problem (insofar as the wishes of the affected community may be ignored). The problem may be a real event that happened in the past or present or it may be a potential event feared to happen in the future.

Your group will select a sociotechnical problem that interests you. You may draw from newspapers, your other courses, or personal experiences for inspiration. You may form groups of your choosing. We will also give opportunities in class for people to share topics and form groups based on mutual interests.

In 1-2 pages, double spaced, you will provide a brief summary of your chosen problem. This summary must (1) clearly explain the context of the problem and (2) clearly explain the question to be addressed. You should not propose a solution at this stage. This proposal should be emailed to jonathan.wald@concordia.ca with all group members clearly indicated.

Step 2 – Annotated Bibliography (10%): Due February 27 on Moodle.

You will need to gather background information on the problem. Identify the communities, technologies, environments, and other factors involved. You will need to conduct research using an academic database. All the articles may come from a single database, but you may want to consider finding a variety of articles for an interdisciplinary topic. When choosing articles, consider the relevance and credibility of the text. If you are researching a relatively new topic, older articles may be outdated. The items on the bibliography must be academic, peer-reviewed articles and not books, newspapers, announcements, “grey literature,” or any other kind of publication.

You will need to find 4 academic articles related to your topic and provide a brief summary that includes an (1) overview of the argument, (2) how the author(s) make that claim, and (3) how this article supports your project. For each article, your annotation should be approximately half a page. The entire bibliography should not exceed 5 pages, double spaced.

Step 3 – Group Presentation (30%): Due last day of class.

Once you understand the problem, you may then identify the range of possible solutions that might address the problem. These solutions do not need to address all facets of the problem (there rarely are such “silver bullets”), but they must at least, in principle, improve the situation somehow. Consider the advantages and disadvantages of these solutions in light of your research. Ultimately, you will create a presentation for a proposed solution. You will want to make the case for this proposal as if you were pitching it to a relevant audience. The format of this presentation will be up to you. For example, you may want to create a poster (the Concordia Print store will be able to assist) or a video. Consider your intended audience when selecting a format. These presentations will be delivered on the final day of class and should take approximately five minutes. There will be time for questions from the class.

Step 4 – Reflection paper: Due November last day of class

In 5 to 6 pages, double-spaced, you will provide an explanation for your proposal and presentation that includes: (1) a concise summary of the problem, (2) a concise summary of the proposal, (3) an explanation of how your research led to your proposal, (4) an explanation of why your group chose a particular presentation format, and (5) a brief summary of the contributions of each group member.

Evaluation of Final Presentation:

Problem	Has a sociotechnical problem clearly been identified and described?	5 points
Policy	Does the proposed policy clearly address the problem? Have both advantages and disadvantages been considered?	10 points
Research	Did the group consider a range of reputable sources to support its conclusions?	5 points
Presentation	Does your presentation provide a clear and compelling case for the proposal?	5 points
Reflection	Does your reflection paper substantially address all the require points (see step 5)?	5 points
TOTAL		30 POINTS